

A Borrowed Recovery?

The 2025 Teacher-Workforce Data for the United States

José Elías Durán Roa¹

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In the year to 2025, 7.9 percent of American public school teachers left education, a rate statistically indistinguishable from the 7.7 percent that prevailed over the fifteen years before the pandemic, and well below the 10.4 percent reached when schools were closing and reopening in chaos. Every age group has drifted back toward its own historical norm. After five years of headlines about teachers fleeing the profession, the exodus is, by the standard measure, over.

I believe the number, which comes from following ninety thousand teachers across linked survey interviews, one year at a time, for two decades. What I do not believe is the comfortable reading of it. Teacher pay stands further behind the graduate labor market than at any point since 2010, the flow of teachers out of the classroom and into the jobs around it is the widest on record, and the typical new recruit is now a forty-two-year-old changing careers rather than a young graduate choosing one. Nothing about teaching became more attractive in 2025.

What became less attractive were the alternatives, once the hottest job market in decades finally cooled. A recovery that rests on the weakness of the competition is not a recovery so much as a loan, and this essay is about the terms.

Fewer pupils, and now fewer teachers

American public schools have been losing students since the fall of 2019, when enrollment peaked at 50.8 million; smaller birth cohorts and the pandemic exodus have since removed 1.4 million pupils, and the official projections point further down. For five years the teaching workforce paid no attention, dipping in 2021, recovering, and standing by 2024 nearly where it had stood at the peak. The result was a quiet improvement in pupil-teacher ratios that nobody designed and few noticed (Figure 1).

In 2025 the workforce finally caught up with its students, falling from 4.54 to 4.37 million qualified teachers, the sharpest one-year decline in the series outside the pandemic itself. Some of this adjustment had to come, because districts staffed up on federal relief money that has now run out, and letting attrition shrink the payroll is how a school system downsizes without ever pronouncing the word layoff.

¹PhD Candidate in Economics, University of Alicante, and Research Intern at the OECD Directorate for Education and Skills. E-mail joseelias.duranroa@ocde.org and joduran@ua.es. The views expressed here are mine and do not represent those of the OECD. All remaining errors are my own.

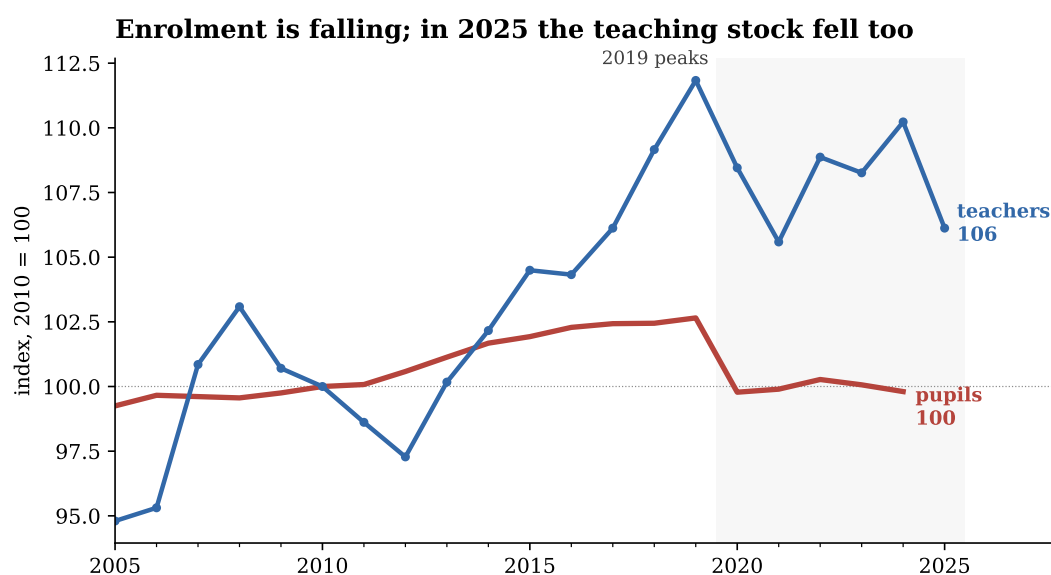


Figure 1: Public-school pupils and full-time qualified teachers, indexed to 2010.

Teachers: CPS monthly data, employed K–12 teachers (occupations 2310–2330) with at least a bachelor’s degree, annual average of weighted monthly stocks; survey estimates carry sampling error of roughly ± 1 –2 percent. The 2025 average covers eleven months, because no CPS was collected in October 2025 during the federal shutdown; the like-for-like eleven-month figure for 2024 (4.52M) confirms the decline is not an artefact. Pupils: NCES, Digest of Education Statistics, table 203.10, fall enrollment in public schools.

A workforce falling in step with its student body is not, on its own, a problem. Whether it becomes one depends on who is leaving and who is arriving, which is what the rest of the data describe.

Two ways to leave a classroom

There are two honest ways to count a lost teacher. The narrow way asks whether she still works anywhere in education; the broad way asks whether she is still teaching a class. The distinction sounds like bookkeeping, and it turns out to carry the whole story of the year (Figure 2).

Counted the narrow way, the crisis is over. Attrition from education sits on its long-run average, and the age profile beneath it has settled as well: the youngest teachers, whose exits rose most sharply after 2020, are back near their own historical rate, while the over-fifties remain structurally the highest because their line carries retirements (Figure 3).

Counted the broad way, the crisis did not end so much as change address. Last year 13.3 percent of public school teachers left the classroom, roughly two points above the old norm, and the wedge between leaving the classroom and leaving education reached its widest point in the twenty years I can measure. Two of every five teachers who left a classroom in 2024 actually stayed in education, becoming instructional coaches, deans, counselors, tutors or college instructors.

For the sector’s payroll this is churn, invisible in the statistics that make headlines. For the school it is the same empty desk at the front of the same room, except that the person who used to stand at it is now down the hall, earning slightly more to teach nobody.

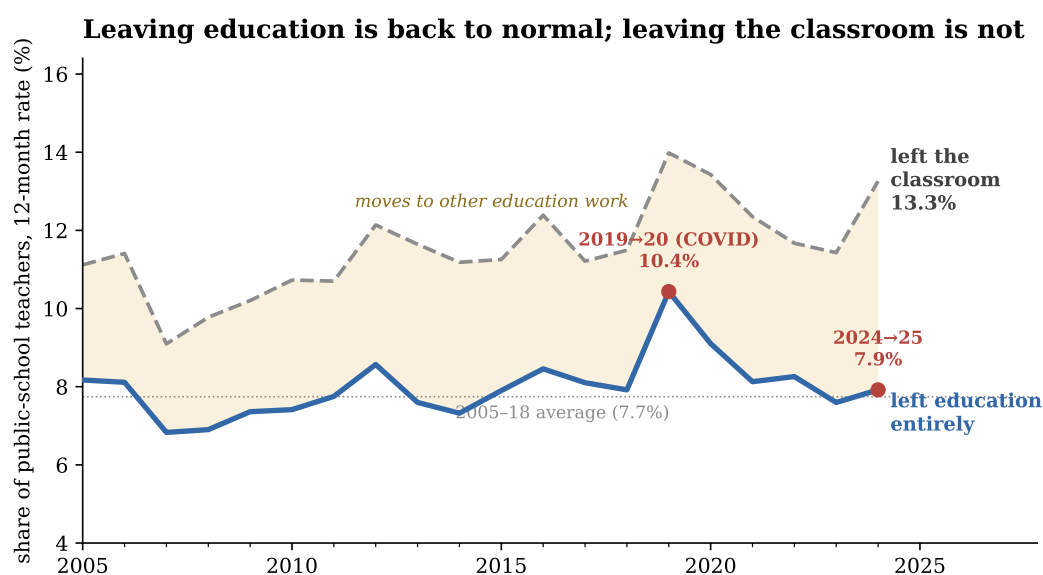


Figure 2: Two ways to leave: out of the classroom, and out of education.

Public-school full-time K–12 teachers with a bachelor’s degree or more, followed twelve months in linked CPS interviews, 2005–2024 base years ($n = 91,035$; 2,841 in 2024, which lacks October links because no October 2025 survey exists). Blue: working in no education occupation at $t+12$ and not teaching in any later interview. Dashed: no longer a classroom teacher by the same standard. The gap between the lines is movement into other education work.

The new teacher is forty-two

Attrition is only half of the ledger; the other half is replacement, and it is the half that looks least like a recovery. The median teacher who entered an American classroom between 2024 and 2025 was forty-two years old, three quarters arrived directly from another job, and fewer than one in five was under thirty. Entries replaced roughly one teacher in six while exits removed one in five, which is the arithmetic behind the shrinking stock of Figure 1, and the profession is aging from the entry door: teachers under thirty-five made up 32 percent of the workforce in the mid-2000s and 29 percent today.

None of this means career changers make worse teachers, and a profession that a forty-two-year-old engineer still wants to join is healthier than one nobody re-enters. Note also that about one apparent leaver in six is back in a classroom within months, a revolving door that quietly softens every flow in this essay.

But consider what the composition implies. Hire a twenty-five-year-old and you buy, in expectation, three decades of future teaching; hire a forty-two-year-old and you buy half of that. And a career changer is, by construction, someone comparing two careers in real time, which makes the inflow exquisitely sensitive to the one variable that has moved steadily in the wrong direction.

The pay that never came back

A teacher at the median earned \$1,380 a week in 2025, in dollars of that year; her counterpart in 2010 earned \$1,462. Fifteen years of budgets, strikes and salary schedules have therefore left the median American teacher nearly 6 percent poorer in real terms, over a period in which the median full-time worker gained 9 percent and the median college graduate gained 3 (Figure 4).

Measured against the graduate market in which teaching actually recruits, teacher pay has slid from 87

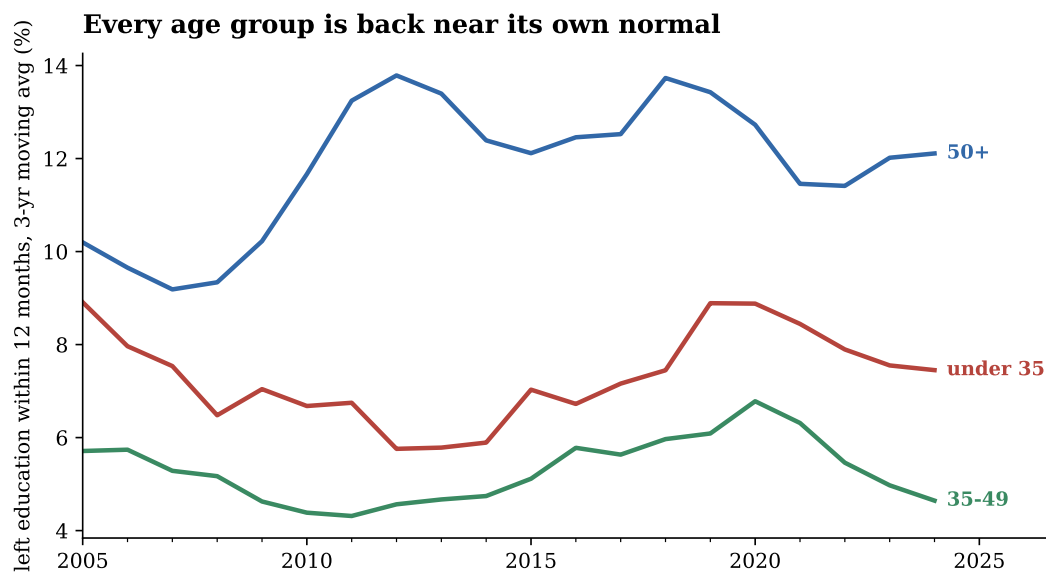


Figure 3: Attrition from education by age of teacher.

Same universe and definition as the blue line of Figure 2, split by age at the base interview; three-year centered moving averages. The 50+ line embeds retirements and is structurally the highest.



Figure 4: Real median weekly earnings: teachers, all graduates, all workers.

Teachers: weighted median usual weekly earnings of full-time K–12 teachers (BA+), CPS outgoing-rotation interviews, deflated by CPI-U. Graduates: BLS median usual weekly earnings, bachelor’s degree and higher, age 25+. All workers: BLS real median usual weekly earnings, age 16+. Indexed to 2010 = 100.

cents on the graduate dollar to 79. The inflation of 2021 to 2023, which salary schedules were too rigid to match, did most of the damage, and the rebound since has recovered less than half of what those two years took.

So the puzzle is this. Teaching pays relatively worse than at any point since 2010, the classroom is leaking into the back office at a record rate, and attrition from the sector nevertheless sits precisely on its long-run average. Something is holding teachers in place, and the pay data say plainly that it is not the pay.

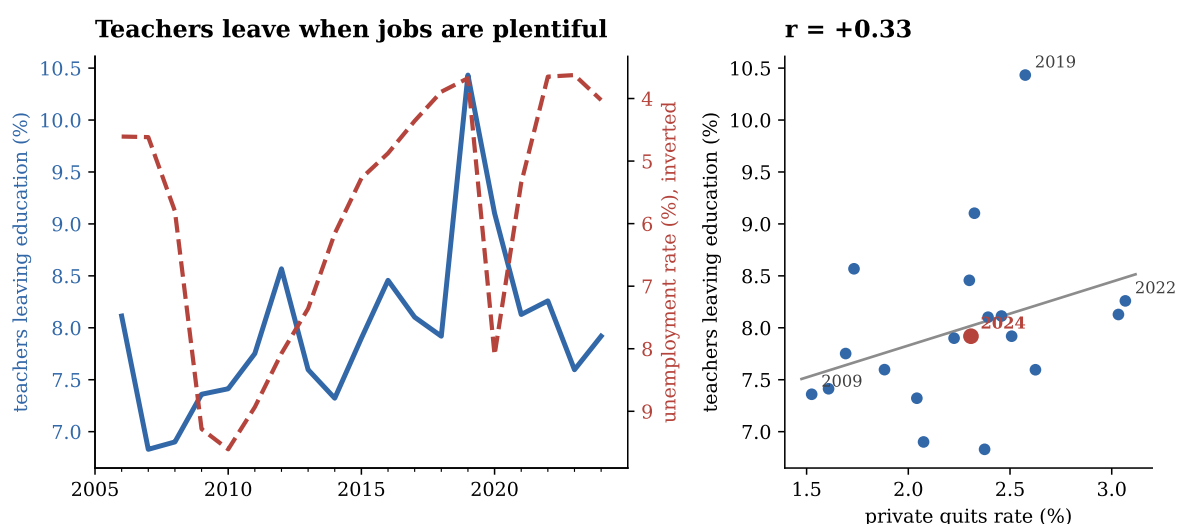


Figure 5: Teacher attrition and the outside labor market.

Left: teachers leaving education (as in Figure 2) and the national unemployment rate (right axis, inverted). Right: the same leaver rate against the private-sector quits rate (JOLTS, annual averages), with an OLS fit; the 2024 point lies on the line. The 2019 observation links into 2020 and carries the COVID shock.

A recovery on loan

Teachers are people, and people quit jobs when there are other jobs to go to. The left panel of Figure 5 plots the rate at which teachers leave education against the national unemployment rate, drawn upside down so that good times point upward, and the two lines breathe together: when unemployment reached ten percent after 2008, teacher attrition sat at the floor of its range, both climbed through the long expansion of the 2010s, and both peaked in the overheated market of 2019 before coming down together. Against the private-sector quits rate, which measures the economy’s willingness to walk out of a job, the correlation across two decades is 0.33. Teachers quit when everyone quits.

Now consider what that market has been doing. Private quits have fallen from 3.1 percent a month at the height of the 2022 frenzy to 2.3, hiring is at its weakest in a decade, and vacancies per unemployed worker are back below their pre-pandemic level. If teacher attrition simply followed its historical relationship with quits, the cooling alone would predict a rate of almost exactly 8 percent; the observed rate is 7.9, and the 2024 point in the right panel of Figure 5 lies on the fitted line to the decimal.

This is the uncomfortable explanation for the good news. Attrition is normal not because teaching recovered but because its competitors weakened, and what a slack market gives, a tight one takes back. The same fitted line implies that a return of quits to their 2022 level would raise attrition by around half a point, with the young and the career changers, the margins already thinnest, moving first.

The window

Read quickly, the 2025 data close the book on the pandemic teacher crisis, with attrition normal, every age group settled and ratios improving. Read carefully, they describe a workforce in remission rather than in health: a stock that is now falling, a classroom that leaks into the jobs beside it, new supply that is old and thin among the young, and pay that is eight points further behind the graduate market than in 2010,

the whole arrangement stabilized by nothing more durable than a slow economy.

School systems control exactly one of those variables. A slack labor market is the cheapest possible moment to restore the relative pay of teachers, and to make the classroom a job worth keeping rather than a stepping stone to the jobs around it, precisely because retention does not need rescuing at the same time. The next boom will re-run the experiment of 2019 on an older, thinner, worse-paid workforce, unless someone uses the interval to change the terms. The 2025 data are not the end of the story; they are the intermission.

A note on the data. Teacher series: CPS basic monthly microdata, January 2005 to December 2025 (Census Bureau; NBER mirror before 2021). The CPS re-interviews each address twelve months apart; persons are linked across interviews and validated on sex, race and age progression, following Madrian and Lefgren (2000). Attrition (Figures 2, 3 and 5) is measured on public-school full-time K–12 teachers, occupations 2310, 2320 and 2330, with a bachelor’s degree or higher, in base rotations that allow re-interviews. A leaver has left the classroom (dashed line) or every education-adjacent occupation (solid line) at $t+12$ and is not observed teaching in any later interview; this definition matches the public-school leaver rates of 7.6 to 8.0 percent in the NCES Teacher Follow-up Survey and the retrospective CPS literature (Harris and Adams, 2007; Aldeman and Yi, 2025). Stocks and earnings use the full K–12 universe including private schools, with final person weights throughout. External series: NCES Digest table 203.10 for enrollment; BLS via FRED for comparator earnings (LEU0252918500, LEU0252881600), quits (JTS1000QUR), unemployment (UNRATE) and the CPI-U deflator. No CPS was collected in October 2025 because of the federal shutdown, so 2025 stocks average eleven months and the 2024–25 links exclude October. Replication code: `src/30_borrowed_recovery_data.py` and `src/31_borrowed_recovery_figures.py`.

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